

Defining Chymistry through Insults?

Michael Maier's Accusations of Alchemical Fraud in the Entrepreneurial Marketplace

Sarah Lang | ORCID: 0000-0002-4618-9481

Max Planck Institute for the History of Science (MPIWG), Berlin, Germany
 slang@mpiwg-berlin.mpg.de

Abstract

This chapter investigates Michael Maier's (1569–1622) strategic use of invectives in his self-fashioning as an expert in the marketplace of entrepreneurial alchemy. Maier's insults not only represent performances of expertise but also defend *aurum potabile* as a medical strategy. Building upon the adage that “the best defense is a good offense”, this study explores how chymists utilized the pervasive notion of alchemical fraud to their advantage. To that end, it examines Maier's works *Coelidonia* (1609), *De Circulo Physico Quadrato* (1616), *Jocus Severus* (1617), and *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum* (1617) as well as his English friend Francis Anthony's *Apologia* (1616), to which he contributed material.

Keywords

Michael Maier (1569–1622) – alchemy – early modern science – fraud – potable gold – invectives

1 Introduction

Michael Maier (1569–1622), a prominent German iatrochemist, is celebrated for his alchemical emblem book *Atalanta fugiens* (1617/1618) and more than twenty Neo-Latin alchemical tracts published during the 1610s.¹ Beyond his prolific writing, Maier was an active practitioner of chymistry, engaging hands-on in the art he so eloquently described. This chapter examines Maier's strategic use

¹ For a biographical overview see Leibenguth, 2002; Tilton, 2003 and Humberg, 2024.

of invectives and apologetic tactics to defend his livelihood against his critics. His personal attacks and defenses testify to the wider disputes and allegations of fraud within alchemy while offering a glimpse into Maier, the practitioner, through the lens of his literary output.

Personal feuds are fought between the lines in many of Maier's printed works, highlighting the challenges he faced throughout his career. Notable incidents include a brawl with a fellow student during his medical studies in Padua, resulting in his abrupt departure, but also his own experiences being defrauded by a fellow alchemist, defending an English friend against fraud accusations, and being banned from the entrepreneurial marketplace in Frankfurt, which compelled Maier to focus on writing and publishing instead of practicing medicine.

Maier's œuvre not only elucidates his conception of chymistry but, more importantly, reveals how he and his contemporaries leveraged the widespread notion of alchemical fraud to their advantage within the competitive marketplace of entrepreneurial alchemy.² The rise of entrepreneurial alchemy in the 16th century, especially in princely courts, was tied to economic pursuits such as mining and technological advances. Patrons fueled the market for entrepreneurial alchemy as a practical technology through their increased demand. Chymists now had to meet the standards of existing industries, leading to a new conception of alchemical fraud, which originally denoted a simple breach of contract rather than moralized deceit in the Holy Roman Empire.

2 On alchemical fraud, see Nummedal, 2004, 2007 and Zuber, 2021. Nummedal, 2007 explores the debates surrounding authentic and fraudulent alchemy, along with broader issues of authority and knowledge in early modern Europe. She reveals how entrepreneurial alchemy, involving more than just the self-fashioning and dissimulation common in courtly life, played a vital role in the economy through trading books, secrets, techniques, and labor. Entrepreneurial alchemists, akin to Italian 'professors of secrets', capitalized on the expanding print market and their unique position between academia and the workshop to profitably share artisanal and natural secrets. Investigating the prevalent notion of alchemical fraud, she shows how early modern discussions about alchemy's nature and limits intersected with the societal and cultural figure of the alchemist (Nummedal, 2007: 5–6; chapter 2 *The Alchemist's Personae*: 40–72; 174–177). Zuber, 2021 analyzes how the widespread narrative of alchemical fraud affected Peter Moritz's work with Robert Boyle (1627–1691) and Ambrose Godfrey (1660–1741). He argues that this alchemical stock tale not only dominated Godfrey's account but actively influenced the events revolving around financial liability and intellectual property in the context of alchemical experiments. The pervasive suspicion of fraud led Boyle and other patrons to withhold their full support. This trapped the entrepreneurial alchemists employed by them in a cycle of failure and mistrust, diminishing their ability to fulfill their alchemical promises due to inadequate resources. Zuber demonstrates that this evolving fraud narrative, internalized rather than explicitly stated, significantly accelerated alchemy's decline in the early 18th century, as it became synonymous with deceit.

Nevertheless, a fraudulent alchemist persona, tainted with immorality, was popularized through Humanist critiques of early modern commerce. In more practical contexts of patronage, chymistry was seen as a potential solution to the economic challenges of the time. Thus, both practitioners and their patrons had a vested interest in attributing alchemical failure to individual practitioners' deceit or incompetence. Maier, while undoubtedly erudite and a scholar, also practiced alchemy in an entrepreneurial way, that is to sustain himself and, quite successfully, as a means to achieve upward social mobility.³

This chapter argues that Michael Maier's invectives, while appearing as simple personal attacks, serve broader purposes under various, yet similar, circumstances. Initially, we note Maier's ambivalent stance towards Paracelsus (1493/94–1541), whom he alternately praises or criticizes to suit his immediate needs. Then, we observe how he crafted his alchemical 'coming of age' narrative, set against his first adversary, Johann Grasse (1560–1618), a Stralsund alchemist who exploited the still inexperienced Maier early in his career.⁴ The defense of potable gold spins through Maier's life like Ariadne's thread. During his stay in England, Maier came to the defense of his associate, Francis Anthony (1550–1623), who was in legal trouble due to his controversial potable gold treatments. After returning to the continent, Maier faced his own set of challenges in Frankfurt while attempting to market Anthony's *aurum potabile*. Now he, too, was confronted with accusations of fraud, which he ardently refuted through his anacreontic poem in *De Circulo Physico Quadrato* (1616). This most vehement invective satirically suggests a lethal dose of hellebore to purge his opponent's madness, an insult just as hyperbolic as it is comical. Promoting *aurum potabile* as a medicine was at the core of Maier's business model and sales proposal. Accordingly, its defense was at the heart of his invectives. Additionally, Maier often employed playful insults in his

3 Nummedal's definition of 'entrepreneurial alchemy' denotes business-oriented practices that do not necessarily exclude scholarly engagement, even though there are many practitioners of entrepreneurial alchemy who did not engage in scholarly discourse. She writes: "Few alchemists were erudite, Latin-speaking scholars who were able to see their ideas into print, nor were they 'important' in the traditional sense of contributing new alchemical theories or practices. *We might think of these more workday practitioners as entrepreneurial alchemists, in the sense that they practiced alchemy not solely for their own edification, but also for the social and material benefits it offered.* Nevertheless, if the majority of alchemists lacked the scholarly distinction of someone like Isaac Newton, their practices were an important part of the engagement with alchemy in the Holy Roman Empire." (Nummedal, 2007: 10. Emphasis added.) In general, see Nummedal, 2007, chapter 2 *The Alchemist's Personae*: 40–72 and chapter 3 *Entrepreneurial Alchemy*: 73–95; as well as 11–13: 177.

4 Though Maier refrains from explicitly naming Grasse, his allusions are sufficiently clear to connect back to him, cf. Leibguth, 2002: 39.

animal court poems, as exemplified in *Jocus Severus* (1617), where he defends Rosicrucianism from a flock of cantankerous birds. An analysis of *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum* (1617) reveals Maier's efforts to defend chymistry as a discipline against allegations of fraud. In this vein, Maier frequently used the notion of false alchemy as a counterpoint to delineate his vision of an ideal chymist, a portrayal closely resembling himself.

This chapter investigates the use of insults and fraud accusations in Michael Maier's writings as a method of self-fashioning his expertise in entrepreneurial alchemy. Through surveying several of Maier's works across his literary career, it provides a panoramic view of his oeuvre. Examining Michael Maier's use of invectives offers not just a fresh perspective on the stock tale of alchemical fraud but also prompts a reevaluation of what defines an entrepreneurial alchemist and how accusations of alchemical fraud are intertwined with this identity. It illuminates the dynamics of who accuses whom of alchemical fraud, revealing that it is not simply a matter of scholars pointing fingers at non-scholarly entrepreneurs. Instead, the accusations of fraud found in Maier's writings are predominantly among scholar-entrepreneurs themselves, challenging each other's legitimacy and expertise.

2 Reasons to Complain: Maier's Life and Work

To comprehend Michael Maier's scientific and professional disputes, it is necessary to briefly review his life.⁵ Born to a gold embroiderer, Maier exhibited academic promise early in his youth.⁶ Maier's career began with a Classical education and an extensive *peregrinatio academica* that took him throughout Europe. He earned the title *poeta laureatus* in Padua but was forced to flee after a violent altercation with a fellow student. In 1596, Maier obtained his doctorate in medicine from Basel and began his alchemical experiments in Königsberg in 1599 while working as a physician. His first significant alchemical work, *De Medicina Regia* or *Coelidonia*, was submitted in 1609 when he sought a position at the court of Rudolf II in Prague, where he was later ennobled as Court Palatine.⁷ During or possibly before his time in Prague, he wrote numerous alchemical tracts, published in quick succession beginning in

5 A biographical overview can be gathered from: Leibenguth, 2002; Tilton, 2003; Humberg, 2024.

6 The *Coelidonia* contains an autobiographical account which is our main source regarding Maier's earlier life: Maier, 1609.

7 Maier, 1609.

1613. Following Rudolf II's death, Maier sought a new patron, first encountering Moritz of Hessen-Kassel (1572–1632) in 1611. In 1612, he traveled to England, where he published the mythoalchemical *Arcana Arcanissima* (1613/1614).⁸ During his stay in England, he befriended the English chymist Francis Anthony (1550–1623), assisting with the Latin translation of Anthony's *Apologie* (1616).⁹ In the summer of 1616, Maier returned to the continent. Stranded in Frankfurt due to illness and barred from practicing medicine or selling Anthony's potable gold, as he had intended, Maier hurriedly wrote 'tractatus itaque 6 vel 7 calente calamo' to sustain himself with the small payment he received for them.¹⁰ It is presumed he had already prepared several of these publications during his Prague stay. He became a physician to Moritz of Hessen-Kassel in early 1618, but his 1618 tract *Viatorium* was already dedicated to a prospective patron.¹¹ Unfortunately, he struggled to find permanent employment until he died in 1622.

8 Maier, 1614.

9 Lenke/Roudet/Tilton, 2014: 4–9.

10 "Atque sic aeger plerumque haerens lecto nonnulla commentatus sum, ad Chymiam spectantia (quorum quaedam proelo subjecta sunt, quaedam subiicienda ab aliis reservantis ad próximas nundinas) lucello, quod inde evenit, magis incitatus, quam maturitate et emendatione ipsorum opusculorum: Tractatus itaque chymicos 6 vel 7 calente calamo deproperavi, sperans me hac via, tantum lucraturum, quo in locum praefixum commodè transmearem" (Frankfurt am Main, Stadt- und Universitätsbibliothek, ms Ff. J. H. Beyer A. 161, 207^v). – "And so, confined to bed due to illness, I have commented various writings on alchemy (some of which have been published, some are held back by others for publication at the next [Frankfurt book] fair), motivated more by the small profit that came from it, rather than the maturity and final edition of these works, I hastily wrote down 6 or 7 chemical treatises with a hot quill, hoping that I would gain enough money by this means, that I could comfortably travel to the predetermined place." Among those were, as Tilton suggests, *De Circulo Physico Quadrato* (1616), *Lusus Serius* (1616), *Jocus Severus* (1617), *Atalanta fugiens* (1617), *Examen Fucorum-Pseudo Chymicorum* (1617), *Silentium Post Clamores* (1617) and *Symbola Aureae Mensae* (1617), see Tilton, 2003: 131. Although some of those had likely already existed in draft form, as a title list on the back of a 1611 letter to Moritz of Hessen-Kassel suggests, assuming the letter is dated correctly and the list was not added later, cf. footnote 199 Leibenguth, 2002: 47. The list mentions 'De Theosophia Aegyptiorum' (an early draft of *Arcana Arcanissima*), 'De natura auri' (possibly *De Circulo Physico-Quadrato*) and 'Hermetis Melica; opus musicum cum germanicis et latinis textibus chemicis; tam intellectui quam sensibus accomodatum 4. et 3. vocibus absolutum' (probably *Atalanta fugiens*); Gesamthochschul-Bibliothek, Kassel, 2^o Ms. ehem. 11 1, f. 64^v. Maier, 1616a, 1616b, 1617a, 1617b, 1617c, 1617d.

11 Maier, 1618b; Maier's employment went on no longer than the end of 1620 at the latest as no mention is made of this employment, which was an important source of income and authority for Maier, in his 1621 *Civitas Corporis*: Maier, 1621; Tilton, 2003: 192.

3 Non ille Bombastus! Maier and Paracelsus

Investigating Maier's stance on Paracelsus, a controversial figure, provides a baseline to interpret Maier's scholarly approach to conflict. Historically, Maier was often labeled a Paracelsian in research literature, a view challenged in the 1990s by scholars like Stiehle.¹² Yet there is, in fact, little evidence that Maier was a supporter of Paracelsus' overall philosophy, as he seldom mentions Paracelsus in his works and often praises figures critical of Paracelsus. Previous research has delineated several viewpoints on Maier's stance towards Paracelsus.¹³ Leibenguth discusses Maier's critical view of Paracelsus but acknowledges Maier's indirect respect for him, rooted in their common reliance on medieval alchemical traditions and regard for medical principles aligning with the Rosicrucian manifestos; he ultimately posits that Maier's critical approach towards Paracelsus should be understood as conciliatory, targeting not Paracelsus himself but his followers for misinterpreting his teachings.¹⁴ In contrast, Wels contests the portrayal of Maier as a Paracelsian, noting that Maier reconciled book learning with empirical knowledge, diverging from typical Paracelsian views that foreground the book of Nature as the main source of chymical knowledge.¹⁵

Maier's ambivalence towards Paracelsus likely stems from a strategic avoidance of confrontation that could hinder his professional interests. For instance, in a letter to a prospective patron, Gebhardt Johann von Alvensleben (1576–1631), Maier appears more receptive to Paracelsianism and magic than in his published works, suggesting a certain opportunistic adaptability in pursuit of financial gain.¹⁶ Maier's primary motivation for invectives and criticisms, thus, seems rooted more in entrepreneurial ambitions than scholarly disagreements. Maier's approach to individuals in his field is characterized by opportunism, portraying them in a light most advantageous to his objectives at any given time. This is indeed the stance we will encounter in all situations of conflict discussed in this chapter. The subsequent examination of examples from Maier's published works will illustrate how his invectives often transcend mere personal attacks, serving broader communicative and strategic purposes.

¹² Stiehle, 1991.

¹³ On Maier's relationship to Paracelsus and Paracelsianism: Stiehle, 1991: 9–10, 247–60; Leibenguth, 2002: 70–73; Tilton, 2003: 60–61; Wels, 2010: 160–63; Kühlmann and Telle, 2013: 956–57; Lang, 2021a: 71–76; Lang, 2023: 114–116.

¹⁴ Leibenguth, 2002: 70–73.

¹⁵ Wels, 2010: 160–63.

¹⁶ Lenke/Roudet/Tilton, 2014.

4 *Coelidonia* (1609) and Maier's First Opponent

Maier's inaugural alchemical publication, *Coelidonia* or *De Medicina Regia* (1609), published in Prague, marks the beginning of his career as an alchemical writer.¹⁷ The date and place of publication are enciphered on the back of the title page.¹⁸ The book is composed of three parts: an autobiographical account of Maier's life up to this point, filled with alchemical tropes,¹⁹ a section on Maier's "god-given medicine" (*Coelidonia*) or *medicina regia & verè Heroica*, and a section detailing experiments from Maier's practice as a physician. Maier's reference to "golden medicine" throughout the book likely alludes to his interest in potable gold, sparked by an English yellow powder's miraculous effects on a patient.²⁰

Book 1 of *Coelidonia* introduces an unnamed antagonist against whom Maier constructs his alchemical hero's journey. This setting is in Danzig, where Maier, residing with a host specializing in the docimasy of metals, encounters alchemy amidst a community of enthusiasts. His first explicit exposure to alchemical theory is through the extensive library of his host during the months the plague ravages the region. He first experiences alchemical experiments with the aforementioned unnamed chymist, whom he would stilize as his arch-enemy in *Coelidonia*. The majority of the first autobiographical book of *Coelidonia* is devoted to Maier's bitter polemic against this individual, who Leibenguth identified as none other than Johann Grasse (1560–1618), a Stralsund jurist and alchemist, who would author *Arcani artificiosissimi aperta arca* in 1617 (Bringer: Frankfurt).²¹ Multiple indirect allusions and references attack Grasse throughout *Coelidonia* without ever explicitly stating his name.²² Grasse's deception, as Maier later admits, consisted only in charging an exorbitant price for misleading information. However, it is staged dramatically within Maier's autobiographical narrative (Lib. I). Maier's intention in *Coelidonia* is to illustrate his arduous ascent to the heights of alchemical theory and practice (Lib. II), culminating in him producing a panacea-like substance, whose effectiveness is demonstrated by numerous case studies in Lib. III. His nemesis is staged as

17 Maier, 1609; Karpenko, 2018; Lang, 2021a: 180–82.

18 Purš and Hausenblasová, 2005: 338.

19 Figala/Neumann, 1994: 136; Leibenguth, 2002: 3, 67.

20 Leibenguth, 2002, 38.

21 Grasse, 1617. Grasse is referred to by the names of 'Grasse', 'Grasshoff', 'Crassaeus', 'Grass(a)eus' and sometimes 'Chortolasseus', although the attribution of this last name to Grasse is uncertain: Telle, 2009.

22 Maier, 1609: 17–18, 23–24.

a contrasting foil and retardation element for Maier's ascent to the ultimate alchemical achievement.²³

Maier visited Grasse one winter after the latter had repeatedly assured him of his alchemical expertise – Maier seems to have believed this without reservation.²⁴ Yet Maier claims to have already harbored suspicions about the one named after grass (*a gramine dictum*) being a fraud but maintained contact in the hope that Grasse could assist him in procuring the true Mercury he sought.²⁵ He eventually labels him *grassator* (bandit), a trenchant pun on Grasse's name.²⁶ After learning that Maier was gaining money from his wealthy patient, Grasse manipulated Maier, who was inexperienced in the harsh business of entrepreneurial alchemy, by supplying him with a steady flow of riddles, charging liberally for his services. This manipulation culminates in Grasse obtaining a significant payment of 400 Thaler from Maier, funds Maier had received from a wealthy patient. Maier's metaphorical comparison of Grasse to a donkey in lion's skin in reference to the Aesopian fable highlights Grasse's pretense of wisdom and authority and suggests that Grasse's intellectual inferiority will result in public embarrassment eventually.²⁷ The analogy underscores Maier's sense of betrayal.

Despite challenges posed by the plague, Maier returned to Holstein in the winter of 1601/1602, making stops at the residences of familiar alchemists en

23 Leibenguth, 2002: 39.

24 Lib. 1: Biiij^r: "[...] mediâ hieme redij ad eum, de quo mihi omnino persuasum erat, eum veram Lapidis cognitionem habere (quod et ipse scripto et verbis mihi, ejusque uxor, aliquoties confessi fuerant) ab eo consilium auxiliumque expetens." Maier, 1609. "[...] in the middle of winter, I returned to him, of whom I was fully persuaded, that he had the true knowledge of the Stone (which both he himself and his wife had confessed to me in writing and in words on several occasions), seeking advice and help from him."

25 Lib. 1: B^r: "Iam dictum à Gramine, ut falsarium, non verum habuisse mercurium cogitavi meque solum jam habere vel mox habiturum speravi." Maier, 1609. "I already thought that the one called after grass did not have the true Mercury, like a deceiver, and hoped that only I already had it or would have it soon."

26 Lib. 1: Biiij^rf: "Verum quibus insidijs, quo dolo, unus eorum, tanquam grassator, me circumvenit, alibi dictum est." Maier, 1609. "But how one of them, like a bandit, tricked me with what tricks and fraud, has been said elsewhere."

27 Lib. 1: Biiij^rf: "Ne verò hic acquiescerem omninò, sed suam operam denuò implorarem, scriptis literis omnia mea iterum conturbat; exploratum nempe habens, me ab uno aegro divite mediocre summam accepisse. [...] Inde accidit, ut asinus aures suas sub leoninâ hactenus tectas ostenderit, dum tantus, tamque dives vir à me mutuo petit quadringentos taleros." Maier, 1609. "But so that I would not rest here at all, but would again implore his services, he disturbs all my affairs again in writing; he had indeed found out, that I had received a modest sum from one sick rich man. [...] Hence it happened that the ass showed its ears so far covered with a lion's skin, when such a great and rich man asked me for a loan of four hundred talers."

route. Arriving in Kiel in 1602, he procured materials for his experiments and, still hopeful, ventured to Stralsund to meet Grasse for a third time. During this final visit, Maier realized that Grasse had merely strung him along, offering nothing but misleading information in return for the hard-earned money from Maier's Danzig host. Maier subsequently decided to place his trust in the writings of established alchemical authorities, notably Basilius Valentinus, whose works he would go on to translate into Latin in *Tripus Aureus*.²⁸ Maier's experience illustrates a costly learning experience at the hands of a fraudster who demanded large payments for dubious information, a beginner's mistake. Nevertheless, aside from the financial loss, it seems that Maier emerged from the ordeal without significant lasting damage.

Despite these negative experiences, Maier's later writings show a more neutral stance towards Grasse, whose expertise he eventually seems to respect.²⁹ This shift may reflect Maier's reconsideration or strategic positioning, given Grasse's subsequent publication of an influential alchemical treatise *Arcani Artificiosissimi Aperta Arca. Das ist: Der allergrösten vnd künstlichsten Geheimnüssen der Natur eröffneten vnd offstehender Kasten* in Frankfurt in 1617. Maier continues to reference Grasse in his later works, such as *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum*, using familiar codenames like *grassator notissimus* (*Examen* 2, 21) and *à gramine denominatus* (*Examen* 4, 33).³⁰

5 Defending Potable Gold: Francis Anthony's *Apologia* (1616)

Michael Maier's move away from Königsberg and Danzig was possibly influenced by an encounter with a medicament that would captivate much of his professional life: *aurum potable*, or potable gold. This interest was sparked when Maier's host received a yellow powder from a nobleman, which remarkably cured his ailment. This powder was likely the English "drinking gold" prepared by Francis Anthony (1550–1623), an English physician and alchemist, whom Maier would later befriend during his stay in London.³¹ Anthony, a Cambridge alumnus, was entangled in legal disputes with the College of Physicians due to his *aurum potable*. Though heralded as a miraculous medicine – a view Maier shared from his initial exposure – it had reportedly caused the

28 Maier, 1618a.

29 Leibenguth, 2002: 39.

30 Leibenguth, 2002: 58.

31 Leibenguth, 2002: 38.

death of some patients.³² Maier assisted his friend by translating Anthony's *Apologie* (1616) into Latin.³³ Upon returning to Germany, Maier claimed his role in the project extended beyond translating to substantially co-authoring the work.³⁴ In an introduction he contributed to the front matter of Anthony's 1616 *Apologia*, Maier writes:

Legi vir clarissime tractatum tuum de Auro potabili apud vos in Anglia editum; argumentum sane et intentio bona; qui aliter aestimet, vix mihi inter bonos aestimandus. Flosculos tuos dulcissimos ex Chymiae verae hortis delibatos grato animo lustravi; verum cum illis binos areaneos venenosissimos infidere viderem, exque illo nectare venenum sibi haurire et texere futilia et inutilia retícula, vix me continere potui, quin illos túrgidos et horridos uno ictu ne dicam flatu dissiparem. At cum animadverterem eorum texturas et opuscula permultis admiranda existere, ideo nihil incommodi illis animalculis hactenus inferre volui, ne scilicet Crabrones cum aranéis conspirent. Mitto interim en spongiam Muriaticam, seu muria acri imbutam, qua plagas ab illis bestiolis illatas aut virus infixum elevare, abstergere et sanare possis; aut si mavis, illorum non candidas lituras aut texturas delere et omnino suppressere. [...] Tui nominis observantissimus HERMES MALAVICI.³⁵

'Most distinguished sir, I have read your concise treatise about Potable Gold published in England. Indeed, the argument is sound and the intention noble; anyone who thinks otherwise is scarcely worthy of regard. I have gladly examined your sweet flowers, plucked from the gardens of true chymistry; but when I saw those two most venomous spiders lurking among them, and spilling their poison into their nectar and weaving futile and useless little nets, I could hardly contain myself so as not to scatter those swollen and horrid creatures with a single blow, not to say a fart. However, recognizing that their writings and treatises are admired by many, I restrained from harming these little pests, lest the hornets conspire with the spiders. Meanwhile, I send you a Muriatic sponge, soaked in sharp vinegar, with which you can wash away, cleanse, and heal the wounds and the poison inflicted by those little pests. Or, if you prefer, you

32 Tilton, 2003, 103.

33 Anthony, 1616b.

34 Lenke/Roudet/Tilton, 2014; Lang, 2021b.

35 Anthony, 1616a: ¶ 4^r.

can erase and altogether remove their dirty marks or webs. [...] Observantly yours, HERMES MALAVICI.'

This text is signed 'Hermes Malavici', a known and frequently used name anagram of Maier's, and followed by the poem 'Spongia Muriatica', praising Anthony's English Garden of the Hesperides, home to his potable gold but also infested by two spiders.³⁶ Maier initially sought patronage from Sir William Paddy (1554–1634), to whom he dedicated his *Arcana Arcanissima*.³⁷ Using Maier's name anagram, *Spongia Muriatica* specifically targets Matthew Gwinne (1558?–1627), a friend of Paddy's and co-commissioner of tobacco, as well as fellow chymist Thomas Rawlin. The poem allegorically depicts these critics as envious spiders threatening the Hesperides' garden, with Hermes Malavici proposing a muriatic sponge to remove them delicately.³⁸ This metaphorical approach reflects Maier's cautious stance, likely mindful of the influence of Sir Paddy, who had endorsed Gwinne's refutation of Anthony's *Assertio*³⁹ (*Aurum non Aurum*, 1611) and Rawlin's writings on alchemical fraud (*Admonitio Pseudo-chymicis*, 1612).⁴⁰ Interestingly, Rawlin himself marketed a version of potable gold, opposing Anthony's product in *Admonitio Pseudo-chymicis* not on the grounds of alchemical legitimacy but as a commercial competitor. This scenario illustrates the blurred lines in defining authentic and false alchemists, as Rawlin's business model mirrored that of Maier and Anthony. Maier's poem extensively criticizes Gwinne, with Rawlin receiving less attention. He employs mythological imagery, notably a basilisk, representing Anthony's adversaries, against which Anthony's praised potable gold as an antidote. Maier's approach in this poem is direct in its criticism yet retains his anonymity, perhaps due to concerns about the repercussions from influential figures like Sir Paddy and the legal troubles faced by Anthony. These mutual accusations of fraud may have motivated Maier's subsequent work, *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum* (1617), as he suggests in its introduction:

Cum aliquando in Anglia paucis ab hinc annis nonnihil bilis in eiusmodi fucos alchymicos, aut potius pseudochymicos, collegerim, non potui quiescere, quin eorum delineationem, calamo arrepto, instituerem, tum ut

36 A partial English translation of the poem can be found in: Tilton, 2003: 104.

37 Maier, 1614.

38 Tilton, 2003: 106.

39 Anthony, 1610.

40 Gwinne, 1611; Rawlin, 1612.

animo meo pro tempore indulgerem, tum ut bonis omnibus hanc quasi facem incenderem, [...]

'A few years ago in England, when I had accumulated some bile against such alchemical or rather pseudo-chymical impostors, I could not rest without taking up the pen and sketching their description. I did this both to appease my own mind at the time and to ignite this torch for the benefit of all good people, [...].'⁴¹

In *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum*, Michael Maier appears to directly reference Thomas Rawlin's 1612 work *Admonitio Pseudo-chymicis*, even adopting the term 'pseudo-chymists' for his title, suggesting a deliberate response to Rawlin's critique. Maier's 1619 *Verum Inventum* was a rejoinder to Matthew Gwinne's anti-German sentiments, extolling German contributions to various fields, including theology, medicine, chemistry, and the printing press; it even compares Germany to ancient Egypt as a fertile ground for arts and inventions.⁴² Here, Maier acknowledges Paracelsus as a vital mediator of hermetic science, portraying him as a misunderstood figure emblematic of Germany's cultural legacy.⁴³

6 *De Circulo Physico Quadrato* (1616) and Mental Constipation

Maier's commitment to *aurum potabile* is further evident in *De Circulo Physico Quadrato* (1616). This short work, Maier's first Frankfurt publication after returning from England, is a medico-alchemical treatise focusing on the medicinal virtues of gold and sometimes called his "Monograph on Gold."⁴⁴ Dedicated to Moritz of Hessen-Kassel, it likely served as an application to his later patron.⁴⁵ The title's wordplay alludes to the concept of squaring the (alchemical) circle, relating to gold's perfection.⁴⁶ The treatise delves into the correspondence between gold, the sun, and the heart, exploring the idea that

41 Maier, 1617b: A2^v.

42 Leibenguth, 2002: 55; Tilton, 2003: 37; Kühlmann, 2010: 621; Kühlmann, 2015: 261.

43 Leibenguth, 2002: 73.

44 Leibenguth, 2002: 56; Kühlmann, 2010: 621; Lang, 2021a: 194–97.

45 Moran, 1991: 106.

46 Oosterhoff, 2020.

gold, embodying the perfect circle, also contains a balance of the four elemental qualities.⁴⁷

Maier actively sought the support of a prince interested in alchemy through *De Circulo Physico Quadrato*. In it, he refers to a contentious encounter with a rival in Cologne, whose views on starting materials and *medicina aurea* (golden medicine) clashed with Maier's. This disagreement motivated the publication of *De Circulo Physico Quadrato*.⁴⁸ There are reasons to believe that the invective might target the London physician and censor Gwinne, known for opposing Francis Anthony's *aurum potabile*. However, Leibenguth proposed that Johann Grasse, Maier's familiar adversary, could be the subject.⁴⁹ In his excellent update on Maier's biography, Oliver Humberg was able to demonstrate that the poem is directed at the Cologne professor of medicine Petrus Holtzemius (1570–1651).⁵⁰ The latter had written about Maier in his *Essentia hellebori extracta* and thereby, almost thwarted the publication of Maier's *De Circulo Physico Quadrato*, by accusing Maier of fraud. Consequently, when Maier successfully published his treatise, he triumphantly appended an anacreontic poem (*Cantilena Anacreontica*) to the end of *De Circulo Physico Quadrato*. This poem not only summarizes the work but is also laden with bitter polemic, reflecting Maier's personal grievances. This insult might shed light on why Maier later portrayed himself as the antithesis of a fraudulent alchemist in *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum* (1617). The fact that Holtzemius acknowledged being the target of Maier's insult in the second edition of *Essentia hellebori extracta* supports this interpretation.⁵¹ While Maier directly addresses his conflict with Holtzemius in the summary of his work in the *Cantilena Anacreontica*, he already alludes to this dispute in the dedicatory letter (*Epistola dedicatoria*) of *De Circulo Physico Quadrato*, referring to

47 Maier, 1616a: 50; Tilton, 2003: 183; Kühlmann, 2015: 261.

48 *Epistola dedicatoria*, Maier, 1616a: 4–5; Leibenguth, 2002: 57.

49 Leibenguth, 2002: 427.

50 Humberg, 2024.

51 "Interim dum haec relego, offertur mihi scriptum alicujus Medici, immodicae profecto in me libertatis, Paracelsicae imposturae maximi buccinatoris, fraternitatis roseae crucis, magicae, dico coniurationis, insignis causidici, qui vere ingenium suum ad id dicendi, et scribendi genus idcirco accomodasse videtur, ut aurum suum putatium, quod sub titulo circuli physici quadrati, quasi in auro quadratura siue aequalitas quatuor qualitatum existat, credulo populo dolose obtrudere, et sua sophistica, multififormique scriptione

Holtzemius's practice as *elleborismus*.⁵² Maier's securing of a position with Moritz of Hessen-Kassel, to whom the book is dedicated, in 1618 suggests it was well-calculated to defend his medico-chymical strategy by finally committing his theory to writing, as he says he had been meaning to do for a while.

The *Cantilena Anacreontea*, constituting the twelfth chapter of the *De Circulo Physico Quadrato*, summarizes Maier's arguments against skeptics of gold's medicinal value in alchemy. This poem serves as an invective, countering the critics of *alchemia medica*, especially those doubting the solubility or digestibility of gold. Drawing inspiration from Horace's *Epodes*, Maier employs subtle ambiguities and double meanings. His tactic of using an extra dose of hellebore against Holtzemius echoes the ancient *ius talionis* – fighting back

exornare possit [...].” Petrus Holtzemius, *Essentia hellebori rediviva, secundo extracta sive rectificata et aucta*. Köln: 1623, 31–33.

‘While I am re-reading these things in the meantime (i.e., preparing the second edition of his book), a document is presented to me from a certain doctor, who is truly offensive (intemperately outspoken) towards me, the greatest trumpeter of the Paracelsian imposture and an excellent advocate of the Rosy Cross fraternity – a magical conspiracy, I say –, who appears to have accommodated his natural talent for speaking and writing so that he can cunningly impose his alleged gold, which exists under the designation “natural square circle”, as if the quadrature or balance of the four qualities existed in gold, on the gullible people and embellish it with his sophistry and multifarious writings [...].’

- 52 *Epistola dedicatoria*, Maier, 1616a: 4–5. “Quod scriptum, cum jam pridem de eo concipiendo cogitârim, nunc, dum Coloniae paucis ab hinc diebus subsisterem, mihi extorsit, ferè Ephemerum, cujusdam nimis iniqui et precocis authoris Elleborismus, omnibus Chymicis et ex auro, aliisve metallicis (ut abusus medicinae rectè taxatos non taxem) medicamenta ad hominum salutem spectantia, praeparantibus, instar, fortissimae purgationis propinatus. Cum verò nonnulli inter Chymiae, nostrique amantes hoc inprimis publicari cuperent, ne scilicet Veritas in herba, quod dicitur, supprimatur, at pro cujuslibet virili à calumniis adversantium liberetur, hujus gratiâ hanc arenam descendere non sum veritus, cujus cum Celsitudo Vestra patrocinium nunquam non suscipiat, non est quod dubitem, quin clementissimam eidem jam manum praebitura sit, cui quantulumcunque tractatum dico et obfero, eâmq̃ Divinae protectioni diutissimè commendo. Francfurto ad Moenum: Anno 1616. Mense Augusto.”

‘This writing, which I had long considered conceiving, was wrung from me now, while I stayed in Cologne a few days ago, nearly an Ephemerum, by the Elleborismus of a certain unjust and premature author, offered to all chemists and those preparing medicines for the health of mankind from gold or other metals as a very strong purgation (so as not to unjustly criticize the rightful condemnation of medicine's abuses). Some among our fellow lovers of Chymistry desired its publication, lest truth, as it is said, be suppressed while still in the bud, but be delivered from the calumnies of its adversaries. For the sake of truth, I did not hesitate to engage in this task, descend into this arena, whose patronage Your Highness always accepts, so there is no reason for me to doubt that you will now extend the most gracious hand to it, to which I dedicate and offer this small treatise. In doing so, I commend Your Highness to Divine protection. Frankfurt on the Main: Year 1616. Month of August.’ See also Leibenguth, 2002: 57.

with the opponent's own methods. The iambic poem's meter, a catalectic iambic tetrameter, aligns with the traditional use of iambs for satirical verses.⁵³

Maier begins with a reference to Anticyra, a city famed for its hellebore, used historically as a cure for madness. He employs puns and contrasts to inject irony and humor, suggesting that those doubting gold's medicinal efficacy should undergo purgation with hellebore in Anticyra, to cleanse the mind and sharpen the senses. Maier presents gold not as food but as a medicine with holistic healing properties, akin to laxatives purifying the blood. He details the various remedies from Anticyra, including wolf's milk, honey vinegar, and hellebore. The plant-based drugs discussed by Maier can have powerful effects. Hellebore, especially, can be lethal in large doses. In the early modern era, laxatives like *Euphorbia*, *scammonium*, and *elleborus* were believed to expel harmful fluids from the blood.⁵⁴ Maier lists only herbal drugs (*simplicia*), aligning with his critic's preference, implying that Holtzemius would not find relief from these, but persist in his misguided beliefs. The exaggerated recommendation of a pound of the hellebore concoction for his adversary is hyperbolic, underscoring the perceived severity of his mental constipation.⁵⁵

Hinc stultior Coraebo, Midae sodalis audis,
 Nomen Petrae molaris habens vel omen hinii.
 Euphorbii calentis, vel scammoni triuncem
 Huic oxymellis acris libram vel ELLEBORati
 Offerte, nec sit ullus post exhibenda somnus:
 Purgatius cerebrum quo fiat Elleborato
 Subtiliórque sensus, sagaciórque mentis
 Discursus à tenebris et nube liberatus.
 Non sufficit saburram ter centies per alvum
 Jecisse, duplicatas sed per vices juvabit,
 Ut omne virus efflet per os calumniosum
 Emittat et recessus per Corporis profundos.

'Hence, you are called more foolish than Coraebus, companion of Midas, you carry the name "millstone" or the fate of a hinny (offspring of a male horse and a female donkey). Offer him hot *euphorbium* (spurge) or three ounces of scammony juice, a pound of sharp oxymel (honey vinegar), or

53 Leibenguth, 2002: 427.

54 They were already mentioned by Maier in Maier, 1609: Bl. D^v; Leibenguth, 2002: 434, footnote 32.

55 Leibenguth, 2002: 434, footnote 32.

HELLEBORE, he shall not find sleep afterward. Through the use of hellebore, the brain shall be purified and the senses made more subtle, and the reasoning of the mind becomes more acute, freed from darkness and clouds. It is not enough for him to have expelled the bile three hundred times through the bowels, but it will be helpful to do so twice as many times for a change, so that he exhales every poison through his deceitful mouth and expels them through the inner recesses of his body.⁵⁶

In his *Cantilena Anacreontica*, Maier reasserts the medical benefits of gold and denounces those who reject its therapeutic properties. The lengthy satirical poem culminates in a recommendation of a lethal dose of hellebore to cleanse his opponent's madness. This *elleborismus* treatment, Holtzemius's medical specialty, is used by Maier in a *simile cum simili* approach, turning Holtzemius's own method against him. The suggested half-pound of hellebore is a clear exaggeration, underscoring the absurdity of his adversary's erroneous beliefs.

7 *Jocus Severus* (1617): Rosicrucianism Attacked by Cantankerous Birds

In 1617, Maier dedicated his *Iocus Severus* to the Rosicrucians. This prosimetric debate poem stages the Owl – who personifies *chemia*, the “art of arts” and “science of sciences” –, on trial before a court of birds.⁵⁷ The poem is an apology of *chymia*, in the guise of a bird council, in which the Owl is ultimately elected queen of the birds for her wisdom. Maier categorizes Chymia's critics into three groups: the ignorant (Jay, Magpie, Raven, Goose, Swallow), the greedy (Cuckoo, Jackdaw, Woodpecker, Heron), and those who vociferously defame chymistry. Similar to Maier's *Lusus Serius*, where Mercury is crowned king of animals, plants, and minerals beneficial to humanity, the animal dispute poem *Iocus Severus* employs the *ioca seria* form, a popular communication strategy for precarious knowledge.⁵⁸ According to Maier's preface, the Owl not only represents true chymists but specifically the Brethren of the Rosy Cross, dedicated to the art of *chemia* and the production of the Universal Medicine. Similar strategies of dedicating works to the Rosicrucians to signal to new buyers can

56 Maier, 1616a: 75–79, the passage cited is on page 78. The Latin text and a German translation with brief commentary are provided in Leibenguth, 2002: 427–37, passage quoted 432–435, verses 93–102; commentary: footnote 32, 433.

57 Leibenguth, 2002: 56, 85; Kühlmann, 2015: 262; Lang, 2021a: 236–37.

58 Maier, 1616b; cf. Obermaier, 2010: 311–14; Mulsow, 2012: 18.

be found in Arthur Dee's works for instance.⁵⁹ The absence of direct references to the Rosicrucian Brotherhood in the main text of *Iocus Severus* indicates that the preface was a later addition.⁶⁰

8 *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum* (1617) and Defending Lady Chymia

The emerging persona of the fraudulent alchemist as a social type in the public imagination was recognized as a threat by alchemical authors, leading chymists like Maier to reframe themselves as allies against fraud rather than its perpetrators, distinguishing their authentic alchemical skills from deceptive manipulations.⁶¹ *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum* stands as a warning against the practices of fraudulent alchemical practitioners.⁶² Yet, this work doubles as a performative act within the context of entrepreneurial alchemy, despite ostensibly critiquing it.⁶³ On the surface, the *Examen* serves as a critique of false alchemists but acts as an apology for 'true chymistry' at the same time. Through this dual-purpose framing, Maier strategically crafts his persona as a credible expert within the alchemical marketplace, distancing himself from those he accuses of fraud and thereby establishing the archetype of the ideal chymist. This figure is portrayed as a master of hermeneutics, embodying scholarly values along with moral and ethical ones. Additionally, the *Examen* emphasizes the necessity of a comprehensive education for a 'true researcher of chymistry' (*chymiae verae indagator*).⁶⁴ This education extends beyond practical metallurgy and alchemical theory to include the liberal arts, natural

59 Cf. Piorko, 2019; 2020: 48–68.

60 Tilton, 2003: 132–33.

61 However, the apologetic aspect was part of the alchemical tradition since the late thirteenth century, as evidenced by works such as Newman, 1989; Crisciani & Pereira, 1996; Kahn, 2007, and many more. Michael Maier's work appears towards the culmination of this lineage of apologetic literature, preceding the final contributions to the genre, such as those in Roth-Scholtz's *Deutsches Theatrum Chemicum* (three volumes, 1728–1732).

62 Leibenguth, 2002: 56; Kühlmann, 2010: 621; Lang, 2021a: 229–35.

63 Cf. Nummedal, 2007: 170.

64 Figala/Neumann, 1990: 49; Leibenguth, 2002: 58. Maier insists on distinguishing his discipline as *chymia* or *chemia*, distancing it from *alchemia* or *alcumia*, terms that had acquired negative connotations. In his framework, genuine practitioners are termed *chymici*, while imposters and charlatans are labeled *pseudo-chymici* or alchemists. See Rampling, 2014: 708–10.

philosophy, and other sciences.⁶⁵ Proficiency in Latin is crucial for accessing the substantial literature of the alchemical tradition.⁶⁶

The title of Maier's text, *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-chymicorum detectorum et in gratiam veritatis amantium succincte refutatorum*, which can be translated as "The Swarm of Pseudo-Chymical Drones," is a play on ambiguous words: The term *Examen* refers both to "examination" or "investigation," and "swarm" (of insects), while *fucus*, denotes "false appearance, deception" as well as "drone bee." This allows for an alternative interpretation of the title as "The Swarm of [...] Pseudo-Chemical Drones" rather than the straightforward "Examination of the Exposed Pseudo-Chemical Fraudsters, Briefly Refuted for the Lovers of Truth."⁶⁷ Maier explains this intentional ambiguity in his *Epistola dedicatoria*.⁶⁸ This wordplay between bees and drones evokes a longstanding literary motif, likening the poet to a bee and his poetry to honey, which sweetens the bitterness of medicine (Lucr., *de rerum natura* 1. 934–950) – a trope Maier, as a poet laureate, would have certainly been aware of.⁶⁹ This adds another dimension to the *fucus* pun: Not only does Maier characterize the ideal chymist, busy as a bee, as the opposite of a lazy drone, but he also indirectly describes the chymist, if not as a poet, then at least as a master of hermeneutics, and equates alchemy with poetry or high courtly culture. While Maier does not explicitly mention this dimension, it must have stood out to anybody with a Humanistic background in Classics.

This literary strategy enables Maier to elaborate on the archetype of the ideal chymist, setting it against the backdrop of fraudulent practitioners. Through the subtext and framing of the main text, Maier engages in sophisticated self-fashioning: he not only distances himself from deceitful alchemists but also asserts himself as a trustworthy authority.

The title engraving depicts a modestly dressed chymist before an oven, flanked by three elegantly dressed figures, presumably noble patrons, who offer him laboratory instruments and a purse of money.⁷⁰ Nummedal interprets this as an implicit critique of wealthy patrons who inadvertently encourage fraud by offering substantial financial incentives; thus, placing the responsibility for hiring fraudsters upon the patrons themselves, while good chymists strive to differentiate their authentic practice from that of their deceptive

65 Maier, 1617b: 13–19; Figala/Neumann, 1990: 49.

66 Nummedal, 2007: 36–38.

67 Beck, 1991: 21.

68 Beck, 1991: 26–27.

69 On the trope of bee and honey, see Berrens, 2015.

70 Beck, 1991: 23–26.

counterparts.⁷¹ The epigram accompanying the engraving extols the virtues of hardworking bees that must protect themselves from the lazy but aggressive drones. Through this allegory, Maier characterizes the fraudsters as alchemical dandies preoccupied with appearances not only in their show experiments, but also in their looks, demeanor, and expensive laboratory equipment.

Maier's text distinguishes three types of alchemical practitioners: the true, the unsuccessful, and the fraudulent chymists.⁷² In the introduction of his tract,⁷³ Maier characterizes the false alchemist by their lack of education,⁷⁴ propensity for making empty promises,⁷⁵ emphasis on appearances,⁷⁶ and, most importantly, engagement in fraudulent manipulation, which accounts for the majority of the book's content. Maier's text relies heavily on Heinrich Khunrath regarding this main characteristic of fraudulent manipulation: The fourth chapter of the *Examen* is a translation of Khunrath's *Trewhertzige Warnungs-Vermahnung eines getrewen Liebhabers der Wahrheit* (1597), which Maier replicates nearly verbatim, save for two brief exceptions.⁷⁷

Although the *Examen* may appear at first glance to be a rejection of performative entrepreneurial alchemy, it embodies a "performance [...] of expertise in the marketplace" in its own right.⁷⁸ Accusations of alchemical fraud emerged together with the genre of transmutation histories, both functioning as apologies for alchemy: By attributing failures to the malicious intentions of

71 Nummedal, 2007: 163–64.

72 Nummedal references this tripartite distinction of alchemist personae derived Sebastian Brant's *Narrenschiff* – the deliberately deceptive alchemist or fraud, the incompetent fool or sophist, and the genuine alchemist who achieves success honestly (Nummedal, 2007, chapter 2 *The Alchemist's Personae*: 40–72, especially 55–57). This classification is mirrored in Maier's publications: Beck asserts that the *Examen* (Maier, 1617b) should be considered in connection with two other works by Maier, the *Symbola* (Maier, 1617d) and the *Viatorium* (Maier, 1618b), which collectively examine different facets of chymical practitioners ("artifices") within Maier's taxonomy. In the *Examen*, Maier (like Brant) distinguishes between three types of chymists: the true and successful chymists (whom the *Symbola* praise), the well-meaning and honest but unsuccessful chymists (whom he aspires to guide out of the labyrinth of chemistry with the *Viatorium*), and the false alchemists and frauds (whom he addresses in the *Examen*). As the author persona, Maier assumes different roles in each of the texts: that of historian (*Symbola*), teacher and leader for the confused (*Viatorium*), or apologist and accuser (*Examen*).

73 Maier, 1617b: 12–13.

74 Beck, 1991: 31–39.

75 Beck, 1991: 39–43.

76 Beck, 1991: 43–45.

77 Beck, 1991: 45–57, especially 46. Khunrath, 1597. This suggests the *Examen* might be counted amongst Maier's translations along with *Tripus Aureus* (Maier, 1618a) and Francis Anthony's *Apologia* (1616a).

78 Nummedal, 2007: 170.

individuals rather than the discipline itself, proponents and practitioners could continue to advocate for alchemy as a viable solution for economic issues, sidestepping public failures as arguments against alchemy's practical and intellectual validity.⁷⁹ Maier's *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum* thus parallels the genre of successful transmutation legends, serving as an apologetic narrative for chymistry amidst accusations of alchemical fraud,⁸⁰ which "serve to authenticate the existence of *Betrüger*", just as successful transmutation stories emphasize the credibility and reality of the possibility of transmutation: "Stories of true and false alchemy, in other words, emerged in tandem."⁸¹ Still, fraudulent practices described by Maier and others like him may have been as much fabrications of the alchemical apologetic imagination as the transmutation stories flourishing at the time.⁸² Authors like Maier had vested interests in promoting tales of fraud to bolster their own status as alchemical experts. Those very narratives intended to uphold alchemy's authority, ironically, were later used to critique the discipline during the Enlightenment because they highlighted its problematic side and thus, contributed to its declining public reputation.⁸³ Tara Nummedal argues that such texts played a significant role in the performative aspect of entrepreneurial alchemy, fueling the market just like show experiments.⁸⁴ The controversy surrounding alchemy, intensified by fraud trials, not only tarnished chymistry's public image but also intensified market competition. Despite Maier and others denouncing 'false alchemists' for their focus on appearance and public perception, their publications were motivated by similar desires to secure patronage "because they, too, recognized

79 Nummedal, 2007: 175.

80 See for example: Guldensalk, 1784.

81 Nummedal, 2007: 170. Transmutation legends, often featuring mysterious adepts, emerged between the 16th and 17th centuries and aimed to convince skeptics of alchemy's legitimacy by means other than scholarly argument. These stories often involve anonymous or pseudonymous characters hardly traceable in the historical record, such as Nicolas Flamel. Yet, they offer insight into the mythology surrounding alchemical transmutation and the archetype of the successful alchemist, counterbalancing the image of the fraudulent alchemist. Maier draws on the tropes of transmutation legends in the narrative framing for his autobiographical account in *Coelidonia*. On transmutation legends see Strein, 1999; Prinke, 2010 and Kahn, 2014. Prinke, 2010 specifically examines Michael Sendivogius, a genuinely successful alchemist who diverges from typical narratives of mysterious, ephemeral figures, demonstrating what truly constituted success in alchemical pursuits.

82 Nummedal, 2007: 172.

83 Principe, 2013: 178–81; Zuber, 2021.

84 Nummedal, 2007: 159–75.

that authority in alchemical matters was determined, in part, through performances of expertise in the marketplace.”⁸⁵

9 Conclusion: the Best Defense Is a Good Offense?

This chapter has examined iatrochymist Michael Maier’s use of invectives and apologetic strategies, which, as this study has demonstrated, all revolve around accusations of alchemical fraud.

Maier’s strategies to anticipate criticism and avoid being attacked by others are a fascinating testimony to the tense atmosphere in the scientific communities he moved in. We encounter *saeva scientia* not only in Maier’s flight from Padua following a violent dispute but also through the insults in his publications, even though most of them are indirect. His most aggressive stances emerge when his livelihood and entrepreneurial ambitions are threatened, rather than in cases of scholarly dissent. Maier’s invectives helped him navigate the definition of a reputable practitioner and thus, protect his livelihood as an entrepreneurial alchemist. His insults are themselves performances of expertise, staging fraud and legitimate practice in the competitive alchemical marketplace. Michael Maier’s invectives were multifaceted and motivated by various circumstances. His reluctance to engage in the Paracelsianism debate contrasts with his open support for the Rosicrucian movement. Personal experiences played a significant role in shaping his responses and writings. The Grasse incident serves as a handy narrative frame for Maier as a retardation tactic in his ascent to alchemical success. Holtzemius’ disparaging comments nearly derailed the publication of one of his works. This challenge was personal, yet the response extended beyond Maier’s individual interests as the defense of a medical and entrepreneurial strategy.

Maier’s scholarly reputation is well-established, but this chapter has revealed a pronounced entrepreneurial inclination, not immediately apparent in his celebrated Humanistic mythoalchemical works. It suggests Maier embodied a blend of entrepreneur and scholar, challenging the divide between scholar-alchemists and entrepreneur-fraudsters as a false dichotomy. Far from being merely a theoretician or a master of mythoalchemy, Maier actively engaged in alchemical practice. Unsurprisingly, his use of invective and apologetic strategies was aimed at defending his livelihood as an entrepreneurial alchemist. This analysis illustrates that narratives of fraud did not solely target the more workday practitioners of chymistry but also blurred the lines

85 Nummedal, 2007: 170.

between scholarly and entrepreneurial identities, contrary to what historical figures like Maier might have preferred their audience to believe. In disputes about alchemical fraud in Maier's era, the contention was not simply between scholars and more workday entrepreneurial practitioners, but also amongst scholar-entrepreneurs. Contrary to the notion that those accused of fraud were uneducated or illiterate, each individual implicated in Maier's narratives was, more or less, scholarly and erudite. They were well-versed in Latin and actively contributed to the alchemical discourse through their publications.⁸⁶ This underscores that scholarly debate and entrepreneurial ambition intersected in chymical practice, leading to conflicts not over the legitimacy of alchemy itself but over the authority of its proponents.

This study underscores that the stock tale of alchemical fraud, which Maier may well have orchestrated within his texts, serves more as a narrative strategy than a historical account of actual fraud perpetrated, echoing Tara Nummedal's caution against taking such narratives at face value.⁸⁷ Authors like Maier had vested interests in promoting tales of fraud to bolster their status as alchemical experts by undermining the credibility of other entrepreneurial alchemists in the competition for patronage. The ambiguity in defining alchemical fraud critically influenced the discourse of alchemists like Maier, allowing them to leverage fraud accusations as a tactic to outcompete rivals for patronage. In the absence of formal contracts or legal frameworks, like those characterizing Maier's dealings with Grasse, the definition of fraud becomes subjective and open to debate, reflecting a matter of perspective rather than an offense with clearly spelled-out, objective criteria.

These recurrent allegations reveal a discourse aimed at exonerating alchemy from failure, aligning with Tara Nummedal's conclusions; but mutual accusations of fraud, even among those offering similar products, gradually damaged alchemy's broader reputation, as Mike Zuber has demonstrated.⁸⁸ Accusations of fraud were strategically used as apologetic devices in early modern alchemy. Branding Grasse as a fraud not only validated Maier's transition to legitimate

86 Francis Anthony, probably the least erudite among those implicated in fraud accusations amongst Maier's contemporaries, was critiqued for his Latin, which, while adequate, lacked the Humanistic flair of Maier's. Thus, Anthony's Latin proficiency was questioned, which undermined his credibility as a genuine chymist. Maier assisted Anthony in writing better Latin but Maier himself echoed this sentiment in *Examen*, suggesting that proficiency in Latin and hermeneutics was essential for respectable practitioners. This stance implied that Anthony's weaker Latin skills could detract from his standing as a skilled alchemist, inadvertently aligning him with alchemical fraudsters.

87 Nummedal, 2007: 172.

88 Nummedal, 2007; Zuber, 2021.

practice but primarily functioned as a narrative strategy. Anthony's conflict with Rawlin over potable gold illustrates the strategic use of such invectives in safeguarding entrepreneurial interests without undermining the overall credibility of chymical remedies. Rawlin aimed to eliminate competition, suggesting that negative outcomes under Anthony's care stemmed from his unreliability, not the inefficacy of potable gold itself, thus, implying that, in competent hands, potable gold could indeed fulfill its promises.

Acknowledgments

The author would like to thank Tobias Bulang and Dominik Berrens, the editors of *Daphnis* and this volume, respectively, for their guidance through the editorial process and the anonymous reviewers for their insightful comments. Furthermore, the author is grateful to Aaron Plattner for proofreading the Latin translations. The author also acknowledges financial support by the Max Planck Institute for the History of Science and MPDL.

References

- Anthony, Francis. *Medicinae Chymicae Et Veri Potabilis Auri Assertio in Francisci Antonii Philosophi Et Medici Londinensis Panacea Aurea Sive Tractatus Duo de Ipsius Auro Potabili* (Cambridge: C. Legge, 1610).
- Anthony, Francis. *Apologia Veritatis Illucescentis, Pro Auropotabili* (London: John Legatt, 1616a).
- Anthony, Francis. *The Apologie, or Defence of a Verity Heretofore Published Concerning a Medicine Called Aurum Potabile* (London: John Legatt, 1616b).
- Beck, Wolfgang. *Michael Maiers Examen Fucorum Pseudo-Chymicorum – Eine Schrift Wider Die Falschen Alchemisten*, Dissertation (München: TU München, 1991).
- Berrens, Dominik. "Bienen und Literatur. Überlegungen zu Senecas 84. Lucilius-Brief." In *Antike Naturwissenschaft und Ihre Rezeption*. Band xxv, eds. Jochen Althoff, Sabine Föllinger, and Georg Wöhrle (Trier: Wissenschaftlicher Verlag Trier, 2015), 145–164.
- Crisiani, Chiara, and Michela Pereira. *L'Arte del Sole e della Luna: Alchimia e Filosofia nel Medioevo* (Spoleto: Centro Italiano di Studi sull'Alto Medioevo, 1996).
- Figala, Karin, and Ulrich Neumann. "Michael Maier (1569–1622): New Bio-Bibliographical Material." In *Alchemy Revisited. Proceedings of the International Conference*

- on the History of Alchemy at the University of Groningen. 17–19 April 1989, eds. Z. R. W. M. von Martels (Leiden: Brill, 1990), 34–50.
- Figala, Karin, and Ulrich Neumann. “‘Author Cui Nomen Hermes Malavici.’ New Light on the Biobibliography of Michael Maier (1569–1622).” In *Alchemy and Chemistry in the 16th and 17th Centuries*, eds. Piyo Rattansi and Antonio Clericuzio (Dordrecht: Kluwer Academic Publishers, 1994), 121–148.
- Forshaw, Peter J. “Michael Maier and Mythoalchemy.” In *Furnace and Fugue. A Digital Edition of Michael Maier’s Atalanta fugiens (1618) with Scholarly Commentary*, eds. Tara Nummedal and Donna Bilak (Charlottesville/VA: University of Virginia Press, 2020). www.furnaceandfugue.org.
- Grasse, Johann. *Arcani Artificiosissimi Aperta Arca. Das ist: Der allergrösten vnd künstlichsten Geheimnüssen der Natur eröffneten vnd offstehender Kasten* (Frankfurt: Bringer, 1617).
- Güldenfalk, Siegmund H. *Sammlung von mehr als Hundert Wahrhaften Transmutationsgeschichten, Oder Ganz Ausserordentlich Merkwürdige Beyspiele von Verwandlung Der Metallen in Gold Oder Silber: Nebst Der Art Und Weise Wie Damit Verfahren Worden* (Frankfurt u. a.: Fleischer, 1784). www.mdz-nbn-resolving.de/urn:nbn:de:bvb:12-bsb10726896-9.
- Gwinne, Matthew. *Aurum non Aurum: In assertorem chymicae, sed verae medicinae desertorum, Fra. Anthonivm, Matthaei Gwynn succincta aduersaria* (London: R. Field, 1611).
- Holtzemijs, Petrus. *Essentia hellebori rediviva, secundo extracta sive rectificata et aucta* (Köln: Mylius, Birckmann, 1623).
- Humberg, Oliver. “400 Jahre nach Michael Maier – eine aktualisierte Biographie.” In *Michael Meier und die Formen (al)chemischen Wissens um 1600*, eds. Volkhard Wels and Simon Brandl (Wiesbaden: Harrassowitz, 2024), 33–64.
- Kahn, Didier. *Alchimie et Paracelsisme en France à la Fin de la Renaissance (1567–1625)* (Paris: Librairie Droz, 2007).
- Kahn, Didier. “The Significance of Transmutation in Early Modern Alchemy: The Case of Thurneysser’s Half – Gold Nail.” In *Fake!? Hoaxes, Counterfeits and Deception in Early Modern Science*, eds. Marco Beretta and Maria Conforti (Philadelphia: Science History Institute, 2014), 35–68.
- Karpenko, Vladimír. “Michael Maiera a jeho spis de Medicina Regia (1609) = Michael Maier and His de Medicina Regia (1609).” *Acta Universitatis Carolinae Historia Universitatis Carolinae Pragensis* 58 (1) (2018), 85–96. [www.doi.org/10.14712/23365730.2018.21](https://doi.org/10.14712/23365730.2018.21).
- Khunrath, Heinrich. “Trewhertzige Warnungs-Vermanung/ eines Getrewen Liebhabers der WARHEJT an alle ware Liebhaber der Naturgemessen ALCHEMIAE Transmutatoriae; das/ wegen der Bübischen Handgriffe der betriegerischen Arg-Chymisten/ gut auffacht von nöten [...]” In Khunrath, Heinrich. VON

- HYLEALISCHEN, Das ist/ PRI-MATERIALISCHEN CATHOLISCHEN oder ALGEMEJNEM NATÜRLICHEN CHAOS. Der Naturgemessen ALCHYMIAE vnd ALCHYMISTEN [...]* (Magdeburg: Gene, 1597), 440–469.
- Kühlmann, Wilhelm. “Maier, Michael.” *Killy Literaturlexikon*. 2., vollständig überarbeitete Auflage 7 (2010), 620–623.
- Kühlmann, Wilhelm. “Maier, Michael.” *Frühe Neuzeit in Deutschland 1520–1620. Literaturwissenschaftliches Verfasserlexikon* 4 (2015), 259–70.
- Kühlmann, Wilhelm, and Joachim Telle, eds. *Der Frühparacelsismus*. Dritter Teil / 1 (Berlin, Boston: De Gruyter, 2013).
- Lang, Sarah. *Alchemische Decknamen digital entschlüsseln. Polysemantische Annotation und Machine Reasoning am Beispiel des Korpus des Iatrochymikers Michael Maier (1568–1622)*, PhD thesis (Universität Graz, 2021a).
- Lang, Sarah. “Assessing Michael Maier’s Contributions to Francis Anthony’s *Apologia* (1616) Using Stylometry.” In *CHR 2021: Computational Humanities Research Conference, November 17–19, 2021*, eds. Maud Ehrmann et al. (Amsterdam: CEUR Workshop Proceedings, 2021b). www.ceur-ws.org/Vol-2989/short_paper44.pdf.
- Lang, Sarah. “Digital Scholarly Editions of Alchemical Texts as Tools for Interpretation.” In *Digitale Edition in Österreich*, eds. Roman Bleier and Helmut W. Klug (Norderstedt: Books on Demand, 2023), 111–132. <https://kups.ub.uni-koeln.de/70451>.
- Leibenguth, Erik. *Hermetische Philosophie des Frühbarock. Die “Cantilenae Intellectuales” Michael Maiers. Edition mit Übersetzung, Kommentar und Bio-Bibliographie* (Tübingen: Niemeyer, 2002).
- Lenke, Nils, Nicolas Roudet, and Hereward Tilton. “Michael Maier – Nine Newly Discovered Letters.” *Ambix* 61 (1) (2014), 1–47.
- Maier, Michael. *De Medicina Regia Et Verè Heroica, Coelidonia* (Prague, 1609). https://soeg.kb.dk/permalink/45KBDK_KGL/1pioqof/alma99122412541105763.
- Maier, Michael. *Arcana Arcanissima, Hoc Est, Hieroglyphica Aegyptio-Graeca, Vulgo Necdum Cognita, Ad Demonstrandum Falsorum Apud Antiquos Deorum, Dearum, Heroum, Animatum Et Institutorum, Pro Sacris Receptorum, Originem, Ex Uno Aegyptiorum Artificio, Quod Aurem Animi Et Corporis Medicamentum Peregit, Deductam, Unde Tot Poetarum Allegoriae, Scriptorum Narrationes Fabulosae Et Pertotam Encyclopaediam Errores Sparsi Clarissima Veritatis Luce Manifestantur, Suaeque Tribui Singula Restituuntur, Sex Libris Exposita* (London: Creede, 1614).
- Maier, Michael. *De Circulo Physico, Quadrato: Hoc Est, AURO, Eiusque Virtute Medicinali, Sub Duro Cortice Instar Nuclei Latente; an Et Qualis Inde Petenda Sit, Tractatus Haud Inutilis* (Oppenheim: Jennis, 1616a).
- Maier, Michael. *Lusus Serius, Quo Hermes Sive Mercurius Rex Mundanorum Omnium Sub Homine Existentium, Post Longam Disceptionem in Concilio Octovirali Habitam, Homine Rationali Arbitro, Judicatus Et Constitutus Est* (Oppenheim: Jennis, 1616b).

- Maier, Michael. *Atalanta fugiens, Hoc Est Emblemata Nova de Secretis Naturae Chymica, Accomodata Partim Oculis Et Intellectui, Figuris Cupro Incisis, Adjectisque Sententiis, Epigrammatis Et Notis, Partim Auribus Et Recreationi Animi Plus Minus 50 Fugis Musicalibus Trium Vocum, Quarum Duae Ad Unum Simplicem Melodiam Distichis Canendis Peraptam, Correspondeant, Non Absque, Singularem Jucunditatem Videnda, Legenda, Meditanda, Intelligenda, Dijudicanda, Canenda Et Audienda* (Oppenheim: de Bry, 1617a).
- Maier, Michael. *Examen Fucorum Pseudo-chymicorum Detectorum Et in Gratiam Veritatis Amantium Succincte Refutatorum* (Frankfurt: de Bry, 1617b).
- Maier, Michael. *Silentium post Clamores, Hoc Est, Tractatus Apologeticus, Quo Causae Non Solum Clamorum Seu Revelationem Fraternalitatis Germanicae de r. C. Sed Et Silentii, Seu Non Reddita Ad Singulorum Vota Responsionis, Una Cum Malevolorum Refutatione, Traduntur Et Demonstrantur* (Frankfurt: Jennis, 1617c).
- Maier, Michael. *Symbola Aureae Mensae Duodecim Nationum, Hoc Est, Hermaea Seu Mercurii Festa Ab Heroibus Duodenis Selectis, Artis Chymicae Usu, Sapientia Et Autoritate Paribus Celebrata, Ad Pyropolynicem Seu Adversarium Illum Tot Annis Iactabundum, Virgini Chemiae Iniuriam Argumentis Tam Vitiosis, Quam Conutiis Argutis Inferentem, Confundendum Et Exarmandum, Artifices Vero Optime de Ea Meritis Suis Honori Et Famae Restituendum* (Frankfurt: Jennis, 1617d).
- Maier, Michael. *Tripus Aureus, Hoc Est, Tres Tractatus Chymici Selectissimi, Nempe i. Basili Valentini, Benedictini Ordinis Monachi, Germani. Practica Una Cum 12. Clavibus Et Appendice, Ex Scriptum, Nunc Ex Anglicano Manuscripto in Latinum Translatum, Phrasi Cuiusque Authoris Ut Et Sententia Retenta; III. Cremeri Cuius Abbatis Westmonasteriensis Angli Testamentum, Hactenus Nondum Publicatum, Nunc in Diversarum Nationum Gratiam Editi, Et Figuris Cupro Affabre Incisis Ornati Opera Et Studio Michaelis Maieri* (Frankfurt: Jennis, 1618a).
- Maier, Michael. *Viatorium, Hoc Est, de Montibus Planetarum Septem Seu Metallorum; Tractatus Tam Utilis, Quam Perspicuus, Quo, Ut Indice Mercuriali in Triviis, Vel Ariadne Filo in Labyrintho, Seu Cynosura in Oceano Chymicorum Errorum Immenso, Quilibet Rationalis, Veritatis Amans, Ad Illum, Qui in Montibus Sese Abdidit de Rubeapetra Alexicacum, Omnibus Medicis Desideratum, Investigandum, Uti Poterit* (Oppenheim: de Bry, 1618b).
- Maier, Michael. *Civitas Corporis Humani, a Tyrannide Arthritica Vindicata: Hoc Est, Podagrae, Chiragrae, Et Gonagrae, Quae Velut Tyranni Immanissimi Artus Extremos Obsident, Et Excruciant, Methodica Curatio. Duobus Auxiliis Potissimum Instituta, Ac Deinde Latius Clarissimorum, Praesertim GERMANIAE, Medicorum Testimoniis Comprobata, Inque Medicinae Candidatorum Gratiam Atque Utilitatem Concinnata Et Edita* (Frankfurt am Main: Jennis, 1621).

- Moran, Bruce T. *The Alchemical World of the German Court: Occult Philosophy and Chemical Medicine in the Circle of Moritz of Hessen* (Princeton: Princeton University Press, 1991).
- Mulsow, Martin. *Prekäres Wissen. Eine andere Ideengeschichte der Frühen Neuzeit* (Berlin: Suhrkamp, 2012).
- Newman, William. "Technology and Alchemical Debate in the Late Middle Ages." *Isis* 80 (3) (1989), 423–445.
- Nummedal, Tara E. "The Problem of Fraud in Early Modern Alchemy." In *Shell Games: Studies in Scams, Frauds, and Deceits (1300–1650)*, eds. Mark Crane, Richard Raiswell, and Margaret Reeves (Toronto: CRRS Publications, 2004), 37–58.
- Nummedal, Tara E. *Alchemy and Authority in the Holy Roman Empire* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2007).
- Obermaier, Sabine. "Scherz oder Ernst? Disputatio unter Tieren." In *Disputatio 1200–1800. Form, Funktion und Wirkung eines Leitmediums universitärer Wissenskultur*, eds. Marion Gindhart and Ursula Kundert (Berlin: De Gruyter, 2010), 311–330. www.doi.org/10.1515/9783110227116.4.311.
- Oosterhoff, Richard J. "Learned Failure and the Untutored Mind. Emblem 21 of Atalanta Fugiens." In *Furnace and Fugue. A Digital Edition of Michael Maier's Atalanta fugiens (1618) with Scholarly Commentary*, eds. Tara Nummedal and Donna Bilak (Charlottesville, VA: University of Virginia Press, 2020). www.furnaceandfugue.org.
- Piorko, Megan. "Seventeenth-Century Chymical Collections: A Study of Unique Copies of Fasciculus Chemicus." *Papers of the Bibliographical Society of America* 113 (4) (2019), 409–446.
- Piorko, Megan. *Chymical Collections: Seventeenth Century Textual Transmutations in the Work of Arthur Dee*, PhD thesis (Georgia State University, 2020).
- Principe, Lawrence M. *The Secrets of Alchemy* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2013).
- Prinke, Rafal T. "Michael Sendivogius and the Meanings of Success in Alchemy." In *Chymia: Science and Nature in Medieval and Early Modern Europe*, ed. Miguel López-Pérez (Newcastle upon Tyne: Cambridge Scholars Publications, 2010), 175–231.
- Purš, Ivo, and Jaroslava Hausenblasová. "Kontakty Michaela Maiera s Rudolfem II. v Praze roku 1609. The Contacts of Michael Maier with Rudolf II in Prague in 1609." In *Studia Rudolphina 5. Bulletin Centra Pro Výzkum Umění a Kultury Doby Rudolfa II*, eds. Lubomír Konečný and Beket Bukovinská (Prague: Artefactum, 2005), 51–65.
- Rampling, Jennifer M. "From Alchemy to Chemistry." In *Brill's Encyclopaedia of the Neo-Latin World*, eds. Philip Ford, Jan Bloemendal, and Charles E. Fantazzi (Leiden: Brill, 2014), 705–717.

- Rawlin, Thomas. *Admonitio Pseudo-chymicis: seu Alphabetarium Philosophicum: omnibus doctrinae filiis, et philosophicae medicinae studiosis, verissime, sincere, et plusquam laconica brevitate conscriptum, et in bonum publicum emissum: in quo D.D. Antonii aurum potabile obiter refutatur, et genuina veri auri potabilis, in omnibus creatis delitescens, praeparatio proponitur* (London: Allde, 1612).
- Roth-Scholtz, Friedrich, ed. *Deutsches Theatrum Chemicum*, vol. 1 (Nürnberg: Adam Jonathan Felßecker, 1728).
- Stiehle, Hans Roger. *Michael Maierus Holsatus (1569–1622). Alchemist und Arzt. Ein Beitrag zur naturphilosophischen Medizin in seinen Schriften und zu seinem wissenschaftlichen Qualifikationsprofil*, Dissertation (Technische Universität München, 1991).
- Strein, Jürgen. "Siegmund Heinrich Güldenfalks Sammlung von mehr als 100 Transmutationsgeschichten (1784)." In *Iliaster: Literatur und Naturkunde in der Frühen Neuzeit. Festgabe für Joachim Telle zum 60. Geburtstag*, eds. Wilhelm Kühlmann and Wolf-Dieter Müller-Jahncke (Heidelberg: Manutius Verlag, 1999), 275–283.
- Telle, Joachim. "Grasse, Grass(a)eus, Johann." In *Killy Literaturlexikon*. 2., vollständig überarbeitete Auflage (Berlin, New York: De Gruyter, 2009), 377.
- Tilton, Hereward. *The Quest for the Phoenix. Spiritual Alchemy and Rosicrucianism in the Work of Count Michael Maier (1569–1622)* (Berlin, New York: De Gruyter, 2003).
- Wels, Volkhard. "Poetischer Hermetismus. Michael Maiers Atalanta Fugiens (1617/1618)." In *Konzepte des Hermetismus in der Literatur der Frühen Neuzeit*, eds. Peter-André Alt and Volkhard Wels (Göttingen: V&R Unipress, 2010), 149–194.
- Zuber, Mike A. "Alchemical Promise, the Fraud Narrative and the History of Science from Below: A German adept's encounter with Robert Boyle and Ambrose Godfrey." *Ambix* 68 (1) (2021), 28–48.